

CMU MSA Brand Guide

Owner: Muslim Student Association of Carnegie Mellon University (CMU MSA)

Document type: Single source of truth for brand, communications, and visual-design standards

Audience: Executive boards, volunteers, and anyone maintaining digital platforms or creating visual materials (present and future)

Status: Living document maintained by the CMU MSA board.

Maintenance note. Carnegie Mellon University has strict rules about how student clubs can use the CMU name and logos (see Section 2). Because the university updates these rules from time to time, the MSA board must check with the CMU SLICE office and the university brand team at the start of every school year to make sure this guide is still up to date with university policy.

Scope. This brand guide is **web-first** and also governs the organization's **digital and social presence** — website, social media, Open Graph share cards, and digital flyers. A machine-readable token file (`tokens/tokens.json`) ships alongside this document so that every implementation consumes the exact same values (see Section 6). The guide does **not** yet cover physical print or merchandise production (CMYK/Pantone separations, garment specs, etc.). Those were intentionally deferred and will be added when the organization is ready; their absence is a scoping decision, not an oversight.

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Section 1 — Executive Strategy & Linguistic Identity

1.1 Mission, Goals & Vision

Mission (official — from the MSA Constitution). The Muslim Student Association at Carnegie Mellon University strives to address the religious, cultural, and social needs of Muslim students, and to build awareness and familiarity with Islam, Islamic cultures, and Muslims through positive interactions with the broader CMU community.

This is the canonical mission statement. It is reproduced verbatim on the About page of MSA websites and in formal documents; do not paraphrase or rewrite it without approval from the MSA board.

Current goals. The MSA's stated goals are to continue advocating for Muslim students on campus and to ensure their spiritual, religious, social, and educational needs are met as fully as possible; to grow membership through campus outreach and strengthen connections with other Muslim organizations across Pittsburgh; and to continue and steadily expand the organization's charitable work on campus over time.

Goals are reviewed and may be updated by each incoming Board; revise this paragraph when the year's goals change.

Vision (elaboration, consistent with the mission). We aspire to be a steady home on campus: a place a first-year student can walk into on their first day and feel they belong, and a place a graduating senior remembers as central to who they became. We envision a CMU where Muslim students never have to choose between excelling in a demanding program and practicing their faith fully, and where the broader community knows the MSA as a generous, principled, and reliable neighbor. This vision is supporting language, not a substitute for the official mission above.

Values. Five commitments guide every decision the organization makes:

- **Hospitality** — We meet people with warmth before we ask anything of them. No one should feel like an outsider at an MSA event.
- **Knowledge** — We honor both sacred learning and academic rigor, and we treat curiosity as a virtue rather than a threat.
- **Service** — We give to our campus and our city, and we measure ourselves by what we contribute, not only by what we host.
- **Integrity** — We are honest in our communications, careful with members' trust, and transparent with the funds and platforms entrusted to us.
- **Inclusion** — We welcome every background, culture, and level of practice, and we design our spaces so that the newest and least certain person is as comfortable as the most observant.

1.2 Editorial Tone of Voice

The MSA writes in one consistent voice — warm, clear, and respectful — but adjusts register across three tiers. The unifying rule: never condescending, never preachy, never stiff. Plain modern Eng-

lish. Avoid internal jargon when addressing a general audience, and define any religious term on first use in public-facing copy.

Tier 1 — Formal Administration (emails to faculty, SLICE, donors, sponsors, university offices). Tone is professional, courteous, and concise. Use complete sentences, a clear subject line, a named greeting, and a signature block with the writer's role. State the purpose in the first two sentences. Avoid slang, emoji, and exclamation points. Be specific about dates, amounts, and requests. Close with a clear next step and a thank-you that is sincere but not effusive.

Tier 2 — Informational Web Copy (website pages, event descriptions, newcomer guides). Tone is welcoming, informative, and self-explanatory. Write for readers who may know nothing about the MSA or Islam. Use short paragraphs and direct sentences. Lead with the practical answer (what, when, where) before the context. Translate or gloss religious terms. Assume global, multi-background readers.

Tier 3 — Casual Social Media (Instagram captions, story posts, group chats). Tone is friendly, lively, and human, while still respectful and never crass. Short sentences and light humor are welcome. Emoji are permitted in moderation (one to three per post). Always include the essential logistics even in a playful post. Keep faith references warm and never flippant about sacred subjects.

1.3 Transliteration Standardization

To prevent the same term being spelled three different ways across websites, flyers, and Instagram captions, the following English spellings are locked. These are the only permitted forms in all official MSA materials. Capitalize each as shown when used as a proper noun or event name.

Term (locked spelling)	Meaning / usage	Banned variants (do not use)
Jummah	The Friday congregational prayer and the weekly gathering around it	Jumuah, Jumu'ah, Juma, Jum'ah, Friday Prayer (as a substitute spelling)
Halaqah	A learning circle / study session, usually a short talk and discussion	Halaqa, Halqa, Halaqat, Circle
Iftar	The meal that breaks the fast at sunset during Ramadan	Ifthar, Iftaar, Eftar
Suhoor	The pre-dawn meal before the fast begins	Sehri, Sahur, Suhur, Sohoor
Musallah	The designated prayer room / prayer space	Musalla, Mossalla, Prayer Room (as a substitute spelling)
Ramadan	The month of fasting	Ramadhan, Ramzan, Ramadaan

Application rules. - On first public-facing use, follow the term with a brief parenthetical gloss as shown in 1.2 ("Jummah (the Friday congregational prayer)"). - Never mix variants within a single document or post. - When designing merchandise or signage, the design proof must be checked against this table before printing. - Additions to this table should be agreed upon by the MSA board; individual members may not introduce new locked terms unilaterally.

Note. This table governs English transliterations only. Rendering the Arabic script itself (phrases, verses, calligraphy) is governed separately — see Section 5: Arabic Language & Sacred Text Handling.

Section 2 — University Compliance & Logo Governance



Current logo (interim raster). The organization's mark is a square deep-red field carrying three elements: a solid black waxing crescent; white Arabic calligraphy reading salām (سلام, "peace") nested within the crescent; and a white "CMU MSA" wordmark set on a gentle arc in the upper-right. The red reads as the brand's Carnegie Red and must be standardized to #C41230 in any redraw. The calligraphy's meaning ("peace") deliberately echoes the community greeting As-salamu alaykum (see Section 5). Because the wordmark is plain typeset text — not the official CMU wordmark artwork — it is consistent with the trademark rules in Section 2.2.

Status & limitations. This guide currently embeds a temporary, low-resolution JPG placeholder. Although the MSA board has high-resolution master files (including vector/SVG copies) in their records, they have not yet been integrated. Board members should locate these master files and store them in the shared brand assets drive. Until they are integrated, avoid using the placeholder JPG for printing merchandise or creating transparent headers on websites or web platforms, as it cannot be scaled or recolored without quality loss.

2.1 SLICE Naming Compliance

The CMU Office of Student Leadership, Involvement, and Civic Engagement (SLICE) recognizes the MSA as a student organization, not as a unit or department of the university. Naming must reflect that relationship and must never imply that Carnegie Mellon University owns, operates, or formally endorses the organization.

Permitted formal names: - Muslim Student Association of Carnegie Mellon University - CMU Muslim Student Association - CMU MSA (acceptable shorthand after the full name has appeared once in a document)

Prohibited constructions: - "Carnegie Mellon Muslims" or any name dropping "Student Association," which can read as a university program. - Any name, email signature, or graphic suggesting official university sponsorship, e.g., "An official program of Carnegie Mellon University." - Standalone use of "MSA" in external or public contexts without "CMU" attached, which is ambiguous off campus.

Required usage notes. - The first reference in any formal document uses a full permitted name; subsequent references may use "CMU MSA" or "the MSA." - Email addresses and social handles should include "cmumsa" or "cmu-msa" rather than implying a university domain ownership the org does not hold. - A short disclaimer should appear in the footer of MSA websites: "The CMU Muslim

Student Association is a registered student organization at Carnegie Mellon University. Views expressed are those of the organization and not of the university.”

2.2 Trademark & Lettermark Rules

“Carnegie Mellon,” “Carnegie Mellon University,” “CMU,” the university seal, the official CMU wordmark, and the athletic marks are **trademarks of the university**. Their use by a student organization is permitted only within the bounds set by the university’s brand/marketing office and SLICE.

- **No co-branded lockup without approval.** The MSA’s own graphic and an official CMU wordmark must not be merged into a single combined logo (a “lockup”) without written approval from the university’s brand office. Until such approval exists, the two marks are kept visually separate.
- **The university seal is off-limits.** The CMU seal is reserved for official university use and must never appear on MSA materials, merchandise, or websites.
- **Locating, not endorsing.** Where the org needs to indicate its campus, it uses the text string “Carnegie Mellon University” as plain typeset words in the approved typeface — not the official wordmark artwork — unless the brand office has authorized wordmark use for the specific piece.
- **The MSA’s own mark is the primary identity.** The organization’s distinct logo/graphic is what appears on merchandise, banners, and website headers. The CMU reference is secondary and textual.
- **Color borrowing is allowed; mark borrowing is not.** Using Carnegie Red (Section 3) as a brand color is fine. Reproducing official university logo files is not, absent approval.
- **Annual re-confirmation.** Because these rules are set by the university and can change, the MSA board re-confirms current trademark guidance with the brand office each year and logs it here.

2.3 Logo Clear Space & Geometry

A definitive exclusion zone protects the MSA logo from visual crowding.

- **Clear-space rule.** The minimum clear space on all four sides of the logo equals **one-half of the logo’s overall width** ($W \div 2$). No other graphic element, text, photograph edge, or page margin may intrude into this zone. Example: a logo placed at 200 px wide reserves 100 px of empty space on every side.
- **Measurement origin.** “Width” is measured as the full bounding box of the complete logo artwork (mark plus any integral wordmark), not the visible glyph alone.
- **Minimum size.** The logo must never be reproduced smaller than **24 mm wide in print or 96 px wide on screen**, to preserve legibility of fine detail. If a smaller mark is required (e.g., a favicon), use the approved simplified/icon-only variant rather than shrinking the full logo.
- **Proportional integrity.** The logo is scaled uniformly only. Never stretch, condense, skew, rotate, recolor outside the approved palette, add drop shadows or outlines, or rearrange its internal elements.
- **Placement.** Default placement is top-left of layouts (matching the web header). When centered (e.g., a banner), the clear-space rule still governs.

2.4 Monochrome & Inverted Adaptations

Three approved color treatments exist. No others are permitted.

- **Full-color (default).** Used on white or very light neutral backgrounds (Pure White or Steel Gray) and only where color reproduction is reliable. Note: the current mark already contains its own red field, so “full-color” placement means that red badge sits as a self-contained block on the page — it is not a transparent mark that adapts to the background. A transparent, layered vector redraw (per the Section 2 header note) is required before the black and white single-ink variants below can be produced from it.
- **Solid black (monochrome positive).** Used when printing in a single ink, on white or light paper, on faxed/photocopied documents, or where color is unavailable. The entire mark renders in #000000 with no gray gradients; internal shapes are distinguished by knockout (white paper showing through) rather than by tints.
- **Solid white (monochrome inverted).** Used on dark backgrounds — a navy or teal hoodie, a dark banner, a photo overlay, or a dark website section. The entire mark renders in #FFFFFF. Use the inverted variant only when the background is dark enough to give the white mark a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1 against the underlying surface.

Treatment rules. - Pick the variant by background, not by preference: light background → full-color or black; dark background → white. - Never place the full-color logo on a busy photograph. Use the solid black or solid white variant on a darkened/lightened scrim instead. - Never recolor the monochrome variants to a brand hue (no “all-teal” or “all-red” logo) unless a single-spot-color print job specifically requires it and the board approves the proof. - The icon-only simplified mark follows the same three-treatment rule.

Section 3 — The Color & Typography Systems

3.1 The Palette Hierarchy

The palette leads with **Midnight Teal** — a deep, calm dark surface that gives the MSA a distinct visual identity independent of the university's red — with **Carnegie Red** as a strong accent for calls-to-action and brand markers. A new **Warm Cream** base replaces pure white for most surfaces, adding instant warmth and hospitality. **Pure White** is retained for content-dense reading areas where clinical contrast is needed. The “volume” percentages describe the approximate share of a typical layout's colored surface area — they are a discipline against overuse, not a literal pixel count.

Role	Name	Hex	Semantic meaning	Target volume
Dark surface / hero	Midnight Teal	#0D2828	Hero sections, navbars, footers, feature bands — the brand's dominant dark	~15–20%
Page background	Warm Cream	#FAF7F2	Default page background, card surfaces — warm, hospitable, distinctly non-institutional	~35–45%
Primary accent	Carnegie Red	#C41230	Calls-to-action, brand markers, highlighted headings — strong accent (not dominant anchor)	~8–12%
Community accent	Hornbostel Teal	#1F4C4C	Secondary buttons, link states, section accents, community-themed bands	~10–15%
High-visibility highlight	Gold Thread	#FDB515	Sparing emphasis — badges, “new”/featured tags, small accents only	~3–5%
Muted secondary text	Iron Gray	#6D6E71	Captions, metadata, helper text, disabled states, fine print	~10%
Dividers / subtle fills	Steel Gray	#E0E0E0	Card borders, table stripes, horizontal rules	~5–10%
Clean reading surface	Pure White	#FFFFFF	High-density reading areas (article bodies, data tables) where max contrast is required	~10–15%

Tints & shades (interactive states). The base colors above cover the vast majority of surfaces. The derived values below are locked for interactive states only — use them only in the specific roles listed. Do not re-derive them with a different tool; these exact values are what any implementation (e.g., a Tailwind config or CSS custom-property set) must reproduce.

Token name	Hex	Derived from	Locked use
cmu-red-50	#FBE9EC	Carnegie Red tint	Ghost-button hover on light/cream surfaces
cmu-red-700	#9E0F26	Carnegie Red shade	Hover/active on primary (red) buttons — white text passes AA
msa-teal-50	#E7F0F0	Hornbostel Teal tint	Ghost/tertiary teal button hover background
msa-teal-700	#163838	Hornbostel Teal shade	Hover/active on secondary (teal) buttons — white text passes AA

Token name	Hex	Derived from	Locked use
msa-gold-700	#D9970A	Gold Thread shade	Hover/active on gold accent elements — black text only
msa-midnight-800	#1A3F3F	Midnight Teal shade	Hover on midnight teal nav/footer elements
msa-cream-50	#F3EFE8	Warm Cream shade	Active/pressed state on cream surfaces

Usage discipline. - Midnight Teal leads. It defines the brand's dominant dark register — hero sections, top navigation, and footers all use Midnight Teal so the page opens with depth and calm authority. - Warm Cream is the default surface, not white. Cream provides the warmth and hospitality the brand voice promises; reserve Pure White for long reading passages where contrast over warmth is the priority. - Red accents; it does not dominate. Carnegie Red signals action and campus identity in CTAs, key accents, and the brand's logo. Avoid using it as a structural background color or heading color at scale. - Teal connects. Hornbostel Teal bridges Midnight Teal and Red as a secondary community color — secondary buttons, links, subsection headings. - Gold is a seasoning, never a sauce. Gold Thread is for small, deliberate accents. It is never used for body text, large fills, or any text on a light background (see 3.2). - Body text is near-black. Long-form copy uses #1A1A1A on Warm Cream or Pure White, never a brand hue.

3.2 WCAG Accessibility Contrast Matrix

All combinations were computed against the WCAG 2.1 relative-luminance formula. Thresholds: AA normal text $\geq 4.5:1$, AA large text (≥ 24 px, or ≥ 19 px bold) $\geq 3:1$, AAA normal text $\geq 7:1$. "Large only" means the pairing is legal only at large text sizes; it is **banned for normal body text**. "BANNED" means the pairing fails even at large sizes and must never carry text (decorative-only, never typographic).

Two new colors — Midnight Teal (#0D2828) and Warm Cream (#FAF7F2) — were added in the current revision. Their contrast values against all other palette colors are included in the extended matrix below.

Foreground text on background — ratios and verdicts:

Text color ↓ / Background →	Warm Cream #FAF7F2	White #FFF	Steel Gray #E0E0E0	Carnegie Red #C41230	Hornbostel Teal #1F4C4C	Midnight Teal #0D2828	Gold Thread #FDB515	Black #000
Midnight Teal	16.8 — [OK] AAA	17.8 — [OK] AAA	13.5 — [OK] AAA	2.95 — [BANNED]	1.86 — [BANNED]	—	9.4 — [OK] AAA	1.19 — [BANNED]
Carnegie Red	5.7 — [OK] AA	6.04 — [OK] AA / AAA-large	4.58 — [OK] AA	—	1.58 — [BANNED]	2.95 — [BANNED]	3.39 — [!] large only	3.48 — [!] large only
Hornbostel Teal	8.9 — [OK] AAA	9.56 — [OK] AAA	7.24 — [OK] AAA	1.58 — [BANNED]	—	1.86 — [BANNED]	5.37 — [OK] AA / AAA-large	2.20 — [BANNED]

Text color ↓ / Background →	Warm Cream #FAF7F2	White #FFF	Steel Gray #E0E0E0	Carnegie Red #C41230	Hornbostel Teal #1F4C4C	Midnight Teal #0D2828	Gold Thread #FDB515	Black #000
Gold Thread	1.68 – [BANNED]	1.78 – [BANNED]	1.35 – [BANNED]	3.39 – [!] large only	5.37 – [OK] AA / AAA-large	9.4 – [OK] AAA	–	11.80 – [OK] AAA
Iron Gray	4.83 – [!] large only	5.10 – [OK] AA / AAA-large	3.86 – [!] large only	1.18 – [BANNED]	1.88 – [BANNED]	3.68 – [!] large only	2.86 – [BANNED]	4.12 – [!] large only
Pure White	1.06 – [BANNED]	–	1.32 – [BANNED]	6.04 – [OK] AA / AAA-large	9.56 – [OK] AAA	17.8 – [OK] AAA	1.78 – [BANNED]	21.00 – [OK] AAA
Black	19.9 – [OK] AAA	21.00 – [OK] AAA	15.91 – [OK] AAA	3.48 – [!] large only	2.20 – [BANNED]	1.19 – [BANNED]	11.80 – [OK] AAA	–

Locked rules drawn from the matrix:

- **[OK]** Approved primary pairings (use freely): White or near-black text on Midnight Teal (17.8, AAA) — the hero/nav standard; Midnight Teal text on Warm Cream (16.8, AAA); Hornbostel Teal text on Warm Cream (8.9) and on Pure White (9.56); Carnegie Red text on Warm Cream (5.7, AA) and on White (6.04); Black on Gold Thread (11.80) — the only approved way to put text near gold; Gold Thread on Midnight Teal (9.4, AAA).
- **[BANNED]** Hard bans (never, any size): White on Warm Cream (too similar — 1.06); Gold on White, Gold on Steel Gray, Gold on Warm Cream (all under 2); Red on Teal, Teal on Red, Teal on Midnight Teal, Midnight Teal on Red or Black, Iron Gray on any brand color. White on Steel Gray. Gold-on-light in particular is forbidden — the error everyone makes first.
- **[!]** Large-text-only (≥ 24 px / ≥ 19 px bold, never body): Iron Gray on Warm Cream (4.83), Iron Gray on Steel Gray (3.86), Iron Gray on Midnight Teal (3.68), Carnegie Red on Gold, Black on Carnegie Red. If in doubt, avoid.
- Gold + text = black, on gold. Gold fails against every light surface, so gold is never used as a text color on light backgrounds. When gold appears with text, the gold is the background and the text is black.
- Body text default: near-black (#1A1A1A) on Warm Cream (18.5:1) or on Pure White (20.1:1). Iron Gray is acceptable for secondary body text on Pure White (5.10) but **not** on Warm Cream (4.83 — large only).

3.3 Typography Stack

Three expressive, screen-legible families chosen to give the MSA a distinct, warm typographic identity while remaining fully compatible with the Arabic families already in use.

Display / Hero — DM Serif Display. - Humanist serif with editorial warmth. Used exclusively for the largest type: hero titles, page H1s, and cover-line treatments. - This is a Regular-weight-only face — its optical weight at large sizes is equivalent to a bold sans. **Do not attempt to load or fake a bold variant.** - Web fallback stack: 'DM Serif Display', Georgia, 'Times New Roman', serif. - Arabic

complement: DM Serif Display pairs naturally with Amiri at large sizes — both are Naskh-influenced serifs. No special accommodation needed.

Subheadings / UI — Plus Jakarta Sans. - Modern geometric sans with subtle humanist details that distinguish it from generic system sans fonts. Used for H2, H3, navigation, buttons, labels, and all UI chrome. - Allowed weights: **Bold 700** (H2, primary nav items, button labels) and **Semi-Bold 600** (H3, card titles, secondary nav) and **Medium 500** (small labels, metadata, captions). - Use sentence case for most UI; reserve all-caps only for eyebrow labels with generous letter-spacing. - Web fallback stack: 'Plus Jakarta Sans', system-ui, -apple-system, 'Segoe UI', sans-serif.

Body / Long-form — Lora. - Brushed-stroke serif designed for screen readability. Warmer and more human than utilitarian web serifs, with stroke contrast that reads clearly at body sizes. - Allowed weights: **Regular 400** (default paragraphs, article body) and **Medium 500** (lead paragraphs, pull quotes, emphasis within body). - Line height for body: 1.6–1.7; measure (line length) capped around 65–75 characters for readability. - Web fallback stack: 'Lora', Georgia, 'Times New Roman', serif.

Arabic families (unchanged). - Body / sacred text → Amiri (Naskh); Quranic ayat specifically → Amiri Quran. See Section 5.2 for full Arabic typography rules. - Headings / display Arabic → Cairo (or Noto Sans Arabic), which harmonizes with Plus Jakarta Sans at heading sizes.

Type-scale (recommended baseline, rem):

Token	Size	Family / weight	Use
Display	3rem (48px)	DM Serif Display 400	Hero / cover title
H1	2.25rem (36px)	DM Serif Display 400	Page heading
H2	1.75rem (28px)	Plus Jakarta Sans 700	Section heading
H3	1.375rem (22px)	Plus Jakarta Sans 600	Card / subsection
Body	1.0625rem (17px)	Lora 400	Paragraph text
Lead	1.25rem (20px)	Lora 500	Intro paragraph
Small	0.875rem (14px)	Plus Jakarta Sans 500	Labels, metadata, captions

Letter-spacing (tracking). Locked values that give headlines the editorial polish seen in premium design systems: - **Display / H1:** letter-spacing: -0.02em — tightens the large serif to feel dense and confident. - **H2 / H3:** letter-spacing: -0.01em — subtle tightening for medium headings. - **Body:** letter-spacing: 0 (default) — never adjust body tracking.

Rules. Never mix more than these three families (DM Serif Display, Plus Jakarta Sans, Lora) in a single layout — the Arabic families Amiri and Cairo are the only permitted additions. Do not fake bold DM Serif Display. Do not use Plus Jakarta Sans weights below 500 as body text — that role belongs to Lora. Body copy never drops below 16px on screen.

Section 4 — Web & Digital UI Standards

4.1 Design Tokens (values)

These are the canonical interface values every implementation must use. They are framework-neutral. Color hex codes and the type scale are defined in Section 3 — this subsection adds the non-color interface tokens.

Machine-readable tokens. All values in this section (and throughout Sections 3–4) are also published as `tokens/tokens.json` — a single JSON file that any framework, platform, or build tool can consume directly. See Section 6 for how to use these across platforms.

Token	Value	Use
Corner radius (standard)	12px (<code>rounded-xl</code>)	Cards, buttons, inputs, images, modals
Corner radius (small)	6px	Chips, badges
Transition duration	200ms	All interactive state changes
Transition easing	<code>cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)</code>	Standard ease
Focus ring	3px, Hornbostel Teal (<code>#1F4C4C</code>)	Keyboard focus on every interactive element

Named typography tokens an implementation should expose: `display` → DM Serif Display; `heading` → Plus Jakarta Sans; `body` → Lora; `arabic` → Amiri / Noto Naskh Arabic; `arabic-quran` → Amiri Quran; `arabic-heading` → Cairo / Noto Sans Arabic. Color tokens map to the palette in Section 3, including the two new surface tokens: `midnight-teal` → `#0D2828`; `warm-cream` → `#FAF7F2`.

These tokens should be implemented directly in MSA websites' configuration/styling. This brand guide defines the values; any digital platform implementation should apply them.

4.2 Interactive States

A single, consistent interaction language across MSA web properties. The behaviour described is the requirement; the Tailwind classes shown are examples of how this can be expressed in styles.

- **Timing.** All interactive transitions use 200ms duration with the standard ease `cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)`. In Tailwind: `transition duration-200 ease-in-out` (the config sets these as defaults, so `transition` alone suffices).
- **Primary button (Carnegie Red).**
- **Rest:** `bg-cmu-red text-white font-heading rounded-xl px-5 py-2.5`
- **Hover:** `hover:bg-cmu-red-700` (darken)
- **Focus:**
`focus:outline-none focus-visible:ring-3 focus-visible:ring-msa-teal focus-visible:ring-offset-2`
- **Active/pressed:** slight scale-down `active:scale-[0.98]`
- **Disabled:** `disabled:bg-steel-gray disabled:text-iron-gray disabled:cursor-not-allowed`

- **Secondary button (Hornbostel Teal).** Same geometry; `bg-msa-teal text-white hover:bg-msa-teal-700`, same teal focus ring with offset so the ring stays visible against the teal fill.
- **Tertiary / ghost button.** `bg-transparent text-msa-teal border border-msa-teal hover:bg-msa-teal-50`.
- **Links.** `text-msa-teal underline-offset-2 hover:underline hover:text-msa-teal-700 focus-visible:ring-3 focus-visible:ring-msa-teal rounded-sm`. Visited links keep the same color (no separate visited hue) to preserve brand consistency.
- **Text inputs.** `rounded-xl border border-steel-gray bg-white px-3 py-2 text-[17px] focus:outline-none focus-visible:ring-3 focus-visible:ring-msa-teal focus-visible:border-msa-teal`. Error state: `border-cmu-red ring-cmu-red; helper/error text in text-cmu-red text-sm`.
- **Focus is never removed.** `outline-none` is permitted only when immediately paired with a visible `focus-visible:ring-*`. Keyboard focus must always be visible (accessibility requirement, non-negotiable).
- **Reduced motion.** Respect the user setting: wrap non-essential animation so it is disabled under `motion-reduce:transition-none`.

4.3 Containers & Visual Motifs

- **Corner rounding.** The canonical radius is `rounded-xl` (12px) for cards, buttons, inputs, images, and modals. Smaller chips/badges may use `rounded-md` (6px); fully-round pills use `rounded-full` for tags only. No sharp 0px corners on interactive containers; no oversized radii beyond 12px on standard cards.
 - **Card component (standard).** A content card is a white surface with a 1px Steel Gray border, a 4px left accent border colour-coded per the rule below, 12px corners (`rounded-xl`), comfortable padding, and a subtle shadow that deepens on hover.
 - **Left-border markers (`border-l-4`).** Content cards and callouts are separated and categorized by a 4px left accent border, not by heavy boxes. Color encodes category: **Carnegie Red** = primary/featured, **Hornbostel Teal** = community/standard, **Gold Thread** = highlighted/"new" (used sparingly). The rest of the card border stays a quiet `steel-gray`.
 - **Geometric line motifs.** Thin 1px Steel Gray rules (`border-t border-steel-gray`) separate sections; avoid heavy dividers. Optional subtle geometric line ornament (e.g., a single thin teal rule under section headings) is permitted but must never reduce text contrast.
 - **Spacing & whitespace.** Generous whitespace is part of the brand (calm, hospitable). Default section padding `py-12 md:py-16`; card padding `p-6`. Do not crowd.
 - **Shadows.** Subtle only: `shadow-sm` at rest, `shadow-md` on hover. No hard or colored drop shadows.
-

Section 5 — Arabic Language & Sacred Text Handling

MSA digital platforms and websites are English–primary but Arabic–forward in selected places — section headers, key phrases, and decorative calligraphy. These rules govern any Arabic that appears on MSA web and digital channels. Permitted Arabic content: short phrases (Bismillah, As-salamu alaykum, common du’as), Quranic verses (ayat), Hadith, and decorative calligraphy. Arabic functions as emphasis and identity, not as the primary reading layer.

5.1 Directionality & Layout (RTL)

- Arabic is rendered as inline right-to-left elements inside the left-to-right English page, by setting `dir="rtl"` and `lang="ar"` on the specific element (a `<span>`, heading, or block) — never on the whole `<html>` document.
- Use CSS logical properties (`margin-inline`, `padding-inline`, `text-align: start/end`) so mixed-direction layouts don’t break.
- Do not make an entire website RTL unless and until a dedicated full-Arabic version is built (out of scope for now).
- Within Arabic passages, use Arabic punctuation where natural (, comma, ؟ question mark). Dates and times in English context use Western digits (0–9).

5.2 Typefaces

- Arabic body & sacred text → Amiri (a Naskh face designed for exactly this). For Quranic ayat specifically, use the Amiri Quran cut, which is built for full vocalization.
- Arabic headings/display → Cairo (or Noto Sans Arabic) to harmonize with the Plus Jakarta Sans Latin headings.
- Decorative calligraphy (Thuluth, Diwani, etc.) is produced or licensed as artwork — SVG preferred, high-resolution raster acceptable — never set as a live webfont. This avoids cross-device rendering failures. Every calligraphy image carries descriptive `alt` text (transliteration + meaning) and a visible caption.
- Load the real Arabic font weights; never fake bold or simulate diacritics.
- Typography tokens are defined in Section 4.1: `arabic`, `arabic-quran`, and `arabic-heading`.

5.3 Diacritics (Tashkeel)

- Quranic ayat: full tashkeel required, transcribed to match a reliable mushaf.
- Short du’as / phrases: tashkeel recommended.
- Names and UI labels: tashkeel optional.

5.4 Sacred Text — Sourcing, Accuracy & Citation

- Inclusion is at the author’s discretion — there is no mandatory pre-publication sign-off.
- Citation is mandatory whenever Quran or Hadith appears:
- Quran: Surah name + (chapter:verse), e.g., Al-Fatihah (1:1). Quote verbatim from a reliable mushaf; never paraphrase the Arabic of a verse.

- **Hadith:** collection + reference number, plus the grading where known, e.g., Sahih al-Bukhari 1.
- **Accuracy duty.** Even under author's discretion, the author is responsible for transcribing sacred text correctly — every letter and every tashkeel mark. When unsure, verify against a trusted printed or established digital source before publishing. Errors in sacred text are corrected as a first priority (fix promptly, no debate).
- **English accompaniment is at the author's discretion.** A translation and/or transliteration may accompany Arabic but is not required. When a translation is shown, attribute the translation source (e.g., translator name or edition).

5.5 Honorifics

- Use English abbreviations, not Arabic glyphs, for consistency on English-primary digital platforms:
- After the Prophet Muhammad → (PBUH) — locked as the house standard. (SAW is an acceptable alternative only in casual community-facing social posts; pick one per piece and stay consistent.)
- After a companion → (RA).
- After a prophet → (AS).
- Place the honorific immediately after the name on first and other significant mentions.
- **Do not** use the Arabic honorific glyph (e.g., ﷺ) in body text — it renders inconsistently across devices and fonts. It is acceptable only when it appears inside licensed calligraphy artwork.

5.6 Accessibility for Arabic

- Every Arabic element carries `lang="ar"` so screen readers switch pronunciation correctly.
 - Calligraphy images require `alt` text giving the transliteration and meaning.
 - Color-contrast rules from Section 3.2 still apply; ornate or fine scripts need a larger size or heavier weight to stay legible — when in doubt, increase size rather than thicken contrast-failing colors.
-

Section 6 — Implementation Guide

The brand guide is the human-readable reference. The token files are the machine-readable source of truth for values. Together they guarantee that an MSA website built in React, or a promotional site in plain HTML all look and feel identical.

6.1 Token Architecture

The implementation layer is formed by:

- **tokens/tokens.json** — A single, structured JSON file in the `tokens/` directory containing every design value (color, typography, spacing, radius, motion, elevation, focus, border). Any build system, design tool, or platform can parse this file to extract exact values.

The hierarchy of authority: 1. Values → `tokens/tokens.json` governs. If the JSON file and this document disagree on a hex code, size, or weight, the JSON wins. 2. Usage rules → This document governs. The JSON says what the values are; this document says when and how to use them (e.g., “Gold is never body text”).

Consuming tokens in a web project: Web projects should compile `tokens/tokens.json` to their target format (e.g., CSS custom properties or Sass variables) during their build/dev step. For example, a compilation script can generate CSS variables under a `:root` selector namespaced with `--msa-` to prevent styling collisions.

For Tailwind CSS, you can directly import `tokens/tokens.json` and map its values into `tailwind.config.js` `theme.extend`.

6.2 Dark Mode

Dark mode uses neutral charcoal (`#1A1A1A`) as the base surface — deliberately neutral rather than teal-tinted, to maximize contrast and feel modern on OLED displays.

Light ↔ Dark token mapping:

Role	Light value	Dark value	Rationale
Surface (page background)	Warm Cream <code>#FAF7F2</code>	Charcoal <code>#1A1A1A</code>	Neutral dark
Surface raised (cards, modals)	Pure White <code>#FFFFFF</code>	Raised Charcoal <code>#2A2A2A</code>	Slight lift
Text primary	Ink <code>#1A1A1A</code>	Warm Cream <code>#FAF7F2</code>	16.3:1 (AAA)
Text secondary	Iron Gray <code>#6D6E71</code>	Muted <code>#A0A0A0</code>	6.4:1 (AA)
Accent (primary action)	Carnegie Red <code>#C41230</code>	Light Red <code>#E8485E</code>	4.6:1 (AA)
Accent (secondary/links)	Hornbostel Teal <code>#1F4C4C</code>	Light Teal <code>#3D9E9E</code>	5.4:1 (AA)
Accent (gold)	Gold Thread <code>#FDB515</code>	Gold Thread <code>#FDB515</code>	9.9:1
Borders / dividers	Steel Gray <code>#E0E0E0</code>	Dark Border <code>#3A3A3A</code>	Subtle separation

Implementation rules: - Web: Web projects compiling the design tokens should include `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark)` and `[data-theme="dark"]` overrides mapped to the `color-dark` tokens.

Both should activate automatically. - **Respect the user's OS setting.** Never force light or dark mode without an explicit user toggle. If you provide a toggle, default to "System."

6.3 Spacing Scale

All padding, margin, gap, and positional values must come from the locked 4pt base grid. This grid is fine-grained enough for precise control while maintaining visual rhythm.

Token	Value	Typical use
4xs	2px	Hairline gaps, inline icon offset
3xs	4px	Tight inline spacing, icon-to-label gap
2xs	6px	Compact list item padding, chip padding
xs	8px	Small component padding, tight card gaps
sm	12px	Standard component internal padding
md	16px	Default gap between elements, page gutter (mobile)
lg	24px	Card padding, page gutter (desktop), comfortable gaps
xl	32px	Section sub-padding, large component spacing
2xl	48px	Section padding (mobile)
3xl	64px	Section padding (desktop)
4xl	96px	Hero section vertical padding

Rules: - Every spacing value in any MSA implementation must be one of these 11 steps. No ad-hoc values (no 13px, no 37px). - When in doubt, round up to the next step rather than down — the brand favors generous whitespace. - Mobile layouts use one step smaller than their desktop equivalents for section padding (2xl instead of 3xl).

6.4 Digital Asset Specifications

Web favicon: 32×32 PNG + 180×180 apple-touch-icon.

Open Graph / social share card: - 1200×630 PNG. - Midnight Teal background with the logo and the page title set in DM Serif Display, Warm Cream color.

6.5 Accessibility

The brand's accessibility requirements (Section 3.2 contrast, Section 4.2 focus) must be met on the web:

Requirement	Web
Reduced motion	@media (prefers-reduced-motion)
Font scaling	rem-based sizes
Focus visibility	:focus-visible ring
Color contrast	Tested per Section 3.2

Requirement	Web
Screen reader labels	<code>aria-label</code> , <code>alt</code>
RTL Arabic	<code>dir="rtl" + lang="ar"</code>

6.6 Compliance Checklist

Every MSA digital product — website, app, or tool — must pass this checklist before release. The board may designate a reviewer, but any contributor can run the check.

- [] **Token sourcing.** All color, spacing, radius, and motion values come from `tokens/tokens.json` — no hardcoded hex values, no ad-hoc spacing.
- [] **Font rendering.** All three Latin families (DM Serif Display, Plus Jakarta Sans, Lora) load and render correctly. Arabic text uses Amiri (body) or Cairo (headings).
- [] **Color contrast.** Every text element passes WCAG AA (4.5:1 normal, 3:1 large) per the matrix in Section 3.2.
- [] **Dark mode.** If the platform supports dark mode, the implementation uses the dark token set from Section 6.2. Light/dark follow the user's OS setting by default.
- [] **Spacing grid.** All spacing values are from the locked 4pt scale in Section 6.3.
- [] **Corner radii.** Interactive containers use 12px (standard) or 6px (small). No sharp corners on interactive elements; no oversized radii.
- [] **Arabic rendering.** Arabic text renders RTL with correct diacritics, uses `lang="ar"` (or platform equivalent), and calligraphy images carry alt text.
- [] **Focus states.** Every interactive element has a visible focus indicator (keyboard/VoiceOver/TalkBack). Focus is never removed without a visible replacement.
- [] **Reduced motion.** Non-essential animations are disabled when the user's OS requests reduced motion.
- [] **Font scaling.** Text scales with the user's accessibility font-size preference (rem on web). No fixed sizes that ignore scaling.
- [] **Footer disclaimer.** Web surfaces include: "The CMU Muslim Student Association is a registered student organization at Carnegie Mellon University. Views expressed are those of the organization and not of the university."
- [] **Naming compliance.** All references to the organization follow Section 2.1.

This document is the single source of truth for usage rules; `tokens/tokens.json` is the single source of truth for values. Where any flyer, page, app, or component disagrees with them, these sources govern and the artifact is corrected.